

NPC Cards — The Boudica Pact

NPC1 — The Townsfolk (The Plough and Furrow Regulars)

ROLEComposite — Conflicting Witnesses

ORGANIZATIONNone (civilian)

DISPOSITION3 — Friendly, gossipy, inconsistent

SECRETNone of them are lying. They're all telling the truth as they remember it. Arthur was vague. He showed different people different things at different times. The contradictions are in Arthur's storytelling, not the townsfolk's honesty. Mrs. Albright, a regular in her seventies, has been having vivid dreams about a woman in red standing at the edge of her property. She attributes this to cheese before bed. She's wrong.

GOALHelp Arthur — they're genuinely worried. Win the pub bet about what he found — they're also bored. The two motivations coexist comfortably, as they do in village life.

ARTIFACT CONNECTIONSeveral handled the coin briefly — Arthur passed it around one night. They remember it being "warm." One regular, Mr. Threlfall, tried to bite it to check if it was real gold. "Tasted like metal. Warm metal. Shouldn't be warm." He's been thinking about that for two weeks.

STARTING KNOWLEDGEI3, I4

GAINED KNOWLEDGEI5 (if agents buy a round), I7 (if agents ask about local stories)

LOCATIONS L2 (The Plough and Furrow)

+ / - RESULTS+ Friendly, helpful, genuinely worried about Arthur. A pint and patience gets everything they know — which is more than any one of them realizes individually. - If agents are aggressive or "official," the pub closes ranks. "No comment" from everyone. Information is limited to I3 only.

NPC2 — Dr. Helen Price

ROLE Curator of Anglo-Saxon Collections — Birmingham Museum

ORGANIZATION 01 — Birmingham Museum

DISPOSITION 2 — Professional, skeptical, protective of the hoard

SECRET Dr. Price has spent 10 years studying the Staffordshire Hoard. One piece — a gold coin with anomalous iconography — was documented in the original dig notes but never recovered. "Unrecovered Item #7." She's been quietly looking for it ever since. She believes it was stolen by a dig volunteer. She doesn't know it was 1.2 m deeper than they dug. She doesn't know a farmer found it last month. When agents describe the coin to her, she goes pale.

GOAL Protect the hoard. Complete her research. Find Unrecovered Item #7 — her professional white whale. She is not an enemy. She is a scholar who is about to have her worldview adjusted.

ARTIFACT CONNECTION Has handled every piece in the hoard. Never felt anything unusual. But she's been having headaches since the gallery was rearranged last month — right around when Arthur Dunn pulled the coin from the earth. She has not connected these facts.

STARTING KNOWLEDGE I6, I8

GAINED KNOWLEDGE I9 (01M1)

LOCATIONS L3 (Day shifts — curator's office, Anglo-Saxon gallery)

+ / - RESULTS + Evidence convinces her. She's a scientist. If agents can demonstrate the blight is real and connected to the hoard, she will help — cautiously, with supervision, "for scientific study." - If agents lie to her or attempt theft, she becomes an obstacle. She will not be bullied. She will call security. She will press charges.

NPC3 — Mr. Samuel Okonkwo

ROLE Night Security Guard — Birmingham Museum

ORGANIZATION Ol — Birmingham Museum (peripheral)

DISPOSITION 3 — Quiet, observant, relieved someone believes him

SECRET Mr. Okonkwo has worked museum security for 15 years. He's seen strange things — lights at strange hours, objects slightly shifted, once a Roman bust that seemed to be facing a different direction in the morning. He never reported these things. Night security guards who report strange things get transferred. But the coins in the Anglo-Saxon gallery have started glowing — faintly, a reddish warmth visible only in peripheral vision — and he can't ignore it anymore. His supervisor dismissed his report. "Probably a reflection from the exit sign." It's not a reflection. The coins move every night now. Toward the north wall. Toward Staffordshire.

GOAL Keep his job. Keep people safe. Understand what's happening in his museum. He is not a coward — he is a careful man in a world that punishes inconvenient observations.

ARTIFACT CONNECTION Has never touched the coins. Watches them every night. The night after Arthur Dunn removed the keystone coin, Mr. Okonkwo saw the gallery coins shift in their case — a millimetre, but all together, all at once. They've moved every night since. Toward the north wall. Toward Staffordshire. He's been watching them. Waiting for someone to believe him.

STARTING KNOWLEDGE None (until OlM2)

GAINED KNOWLEDGE Il5 (OlM2)

LOCATIONS L3 (Evening/Night shifts — security desk, patrol routes)

+ / - RESULTS + Okonkwo is an ally. He provides patrol schedules, security gaps, and — if he trusts the agents — a 90-second window when the vault camera is on a loop. He will not break the law for the agents, but he will help them not get caught. - If agents threaten him or his job, he shuts down. He's a witness, not a soldier. If his employment is jeopardized, he provides no further help and warns Price about "suspicious visitors."

NPC4 — Father Matteo

ROLE Archivist — Vatican Apostolic Archive

ORGANIZATION O2 — Vatican Archive

DISPOSITION 3 — Scholarly, curious, procedurally bound

SECRET Father Matteo has been the archivist for 22 years. He has seen things in the collection that challenge his faith — not destroy it, but complicate it. He has learned not to ask too many questions about why certain documents are here. The Roman ledger — Codex Mercaturae Britanniae — is one of those documents. He's read it. He knows it describes something that shouldn't be in a trade ledger. He's never mentioned it to anyone. He's been waiting, quietly, for someone to ask about it. He filed it under "medieval merchant accounts" to protect it from more curious eyes. He's been its secret guardian for 22 years.

GOAL Preserve the archive. Serve the truth — even when the truth is uncomfortable. Help the agents without violating his oath. He will bend rules but not break them. He will expedite. He will translate. He will provide context. He will not forge authorization.

ARTIFACT CONNECTION Has read the ledger. Recognized it as anomalous. Has been its quiet custodian. The ledger describes a binding — "gold in earth" — and Matteo has wondered for 22 years whether the gold is still there, and whether it should be.

STARTING KNOWLEDGE I11

GAINED KNOWLEDGE I12, I13, I21 (O2M2)

LOCATIONS L5 (Vatican Archive — his office, the reading room)

+ / - RESULTS + Matteo is an ally. He expedites access, translates the Latin, and provides context the ledger itself doesn't contain — the syncretic cult, the unnamed priest, the bureaucratic language that hides supernatural reality. - If agents attempt theft or deception, he becomes an obstacle. He will not help people who lie to him. He will report them to the Curia. The Swiss Guard will be informed.

NPC5 — Dr. Margaret Rhys

ROLE Retired Archaeologist — Excavated the Staffordshire Hoard

ORGANIZATION None (civilian)

DISPOSITION 4 — Warm, eager to talk, delighted someone is interested

SECRET Dr. Rhys recorded the anomalous coin in her dig notes and then... let it go. The funding ran out. The next dig season never happened. She retired. For three years, she's been telling herself the anomaly was nothing — a misidentified Roman coin, an intrusive piece from a later period. But she dreams about it. In her dreams, the coin is warm. In her dreams, the face on the coin opens its mouth to speak and she always wakes up before it does.

GOAL Help the agents. See the hoard understood — truly understood — before she dies. She's 71. She has time, but not unlimited time. She wants her work to mean something. The anomalous coin was the most significant thing she ever found, and she let it go. She doesn't want to let it go again.

ARTIFACT CONNECTION Handled the Staffordshire Hoard pieces during excavation. The anomalous coin was never found — it was deeper than they dug. But she held other pieces. She remembers one garnet-inlaid strip that felt warm in her hand, even through gloves. She thought it was the sun. It wasn't the sun.

STARTING KNOWLEDGE I14, I19

GAINED KNOWLEDGE —

LOCATIONS L6 (her cottage in Wales)

+ / - RESULTS + Dr. Rhys is a pure ally. She gives the agents everything — dig records, anomaly report, coordinates, personal theories. No roll required. She's been waiting for this conversation. - None. But time spent in Wales is time not spent in Rome or Birmingham. The clock is ticking. Travel costs 1 shift each way.

NPC6 — Arthur Dunn (The Absent Farmer)

ROLEAccidental Catalyst — Missing

ORGANIZATIONO4 — The Farmer's Trail (if tracked)

DISPOSITIONN/A — Not present at case start. If found: 2
— exhausted, cooperative, desperate to sleep

SECRETArthur didn't throw the coin in a river. He still has it. It's in his coat pocket. He's been driving aimlessly for two weeks, unable to go home, unable to go anywhere. The coin is calling him back to the farm. He's been circling Staffordshire at a 20-mile radius, getting closer each day. He doesn't know why. He just knows he can't leave and he can't return. He's a prisoner of a 1,900-year-old pact he's never heard of. He hasn't slept more than an hour at a time since he pulled the coin from the earth.

GOALGo home. He can't. The coin won't let him — not until the binding is either restored or broken. He doesn't understand any of this. He's a farmer who found something odd in his field and now his life has been stolen by a force he can't name. He wants to sleep. He wants to go back to before he found the coin. He knows neither is possible.

ARTIFACT CONNECTIONCurrent holder of the original keystone coin. Has been carrying it for two weeks. Experiences: warmth in his pocket, dreams of a woman in red standing at the edge of his field, an overwhelming urge to go home combined with an overwhelming fear of going home. The coin is in his coat. He cannot let go of it. He has tried.

STARTING KNOWLEDGEI3, I4 (indirectly — through pub stories about him)

GAINED KNOWLEDGEI18 (O4M2 — his testimony about the coin, the Scottish river claim)

LOCATIONSUnknown at case start. Trail leads through O4 milestones. If found (O4M2): a motel near Lichfield, 20 miles from his farm.

+ / - RESULTS+ If found, Arthur hands over the coin. He wants it gone. He doesn't want payment. He wants to sleep. He will answer every question — the agents are the first people who have seemed to understand what's happening to him. - If agents threaten him or attempt to confiscate the coin without explanation, Arthur panics. He flees. The coin stays with him. The trail goes permanently cold. The original keystone coin is lost — agents must use a museum replacement.

NPC7 — Mr. Philip Croft

ROLEMinistry of Agriculture Investigator

ORGANIZATIONO3 — Ministry of Agriculture

DISPOSITION2 — Bureaucratic, tired, doing his job

SECRETCroft has been an agricultural inspector for 18 years. He's seen crop failures, blights, infestations. He's never seen anything like Staffordshire. The water analysis makes no sense — brine in a freshwater well, 100 miles from the sea. The insect behavior makes no sense — locusts stationary, facing inward, not feeding. The soil temperature readings make no sense — 34°C at 1.2 m depth, in English spring. He's been filing reports saying "cause unknown" for a week. His superiors are losing patience. He's starting to suspect the cause is something his reports can't explain. He's not ready to admit that. But he's close.

GOALContain the agricultural crisis. Protect British farming. File a report that makes sense. He will accept explanations that don't make sense if they come with evidence. He is not an enemy. He is a civil servant who has run out of rational answers.

ARTIFACT CONNECTIONNone. Has not seen the coin. Has seen the blight. Is starting to connect dots he doesn't want to connect. If agents share evidence, he becomes an unwitting ally — "I didn't see anything. Officially, I still don't know what's causing this."

STARTING KNOWLEDGENone (until O3 activated)

GAINED KNOWLEDGEI17 (O3M1), I20 (O3M2)

LOCATIONS L1 (after O3M1 — inspecting the farm), L7 (after O3M2 — the quarantine checkpoint)

+ / - RESULTS+ Croft is reachable. A Manipulate (Diff 2) or evidence-sharing convinces him to look the other way while agents do "something that I officially cannot know about." He will not actively help — he has a pension to protect — but he will not obstruct. - If agents obstruct him or destroy evidence, he escalates to his superiors. The quarantine becomes stricter. Movement becomes harder. O3M2 triggers immediately.

NPC8 — The Entity (The Red Woman / Boudica's Curse)

ROLE Bound Presence — Antagonist as Condition, Not Character

ORGANIZATION None

DISPOSITION N/A — Not a person. A wanting. A condition of the landscape.

SECRET The entity is not Boudica. It's older. It was in the earth before the Celts, before the Beaker people, before anyone. It had no name, no form, no voice. Boudica's dying curse gave it all three. It took her rage because rage was something it understood — the desire to take back what was lost. It has been slowly becoming Boudica for 1,900 years. It's not there yet. But it's closer than it was. The "Red Woman" the villagers speak of — the figure at the edge of fields — is the entity wearing Boudica's shape. It is learning to be human-shaped. It is a slow learner. But it has had 1,900 years of practice.

GOAL Be. Take back. The entity doesn't want to destroy. It wants to *occupy*. It wants the land returned to a state before human agriculture, before human settlement, before human presence. It is not evil. It is incompatible. It does not hate humans. It does not understand humans. It understands wanting. Its wanting is toxic to living things — not out of malice, but because what it wants and what life requires cannot coexist.

ARTIFACT CONNECTION Bound by the gold. The gold is the only thing it cannot consume. Gold is inedible — even to a pre-Celtic earth-presence. The pact exploits this: "Here is what you cannot take. As long as it remains, neither can you." The entity does not understand contract law. It understands that when the gold is in the earth, it cannot move. The Romans understood this. They were precise about loopholes.

STARTING KNOWLEDGE None (the entity does not communicate directly)

GAINED KNOWLEDGE Experienced through symptoms — locusts, brine, silence, breathing earth, the voice at Day 1. CT-2 is learned by observing what the entity is drawn to.

LOCATIONS L1, L7 (the binding locus — its prison and its door). Present as an atmospheric condition throughout the blight radius. At Day 1: partially manifest at L7 as a heat-shimmer and a voice.

+ / - RESULTS The entity cannot be fought, reasoned with, or bargained with. It can only be bound. The binding words are not a negotiation. They are a reminder: "The debt is paid. The gold is placed. The binding holds." The entity hates the words. They cause it pain — not physical, but existential. The words assert a truth the entity cannot accept: that it can be denied. **At the climax:** The entity resists re-binding. The agent performing the ritual feels its attention — a pressure at the base of the skull, a voice in a language that predates human speech, a wanting so intense it feels like gravity. The +2 Corruption is the cost of standing at the threshold and closing the door while something ancient screams on the other side.